

Research Proposal Writing

What is a proposal?

- research refers to search for knowledge
- research means a scientific and systematic search for pertinent information on a specific topic
- any research study should have a proper proposal in written form before it is actually carried out
- A proposal is like a blue print of a building plan before the construction starts

Importance of a Research proposal

A research proposal enables you to:

- outline steps in your proposed research
- think through the research process
- provide intellectual context of the study
- justify your research area
- anticipate challenges in the research process

Key issues

- **Research Problem** (what research problem does the study seek to address)
- **Benefits** (How will the study contribute to existing knowledge)
- **Research methodology** (what processes and procedures shall be employed to answer research questions)
- **Building on literature/theory** (theory informing study/ what related studies say)

Coming up with research topics

- Personal experience.
- Whether you want to evaluate the effectiveness of an intervention or understand how or why it works
- Curiosity about something in the media.
- State of knowledge in the field
- Solving a problem.
- Hot topics under discussion

- Personal values
- Everyday life.
- Gaps in the research and theoretical literature.
- How do you come up with a research topic:
 - Start with a broad area of interest (human resource management in schools, financial management in schools, learner discipline in schools, failure rate in schools, reading problems, writing problems, students class attendance, parents' involvement in students in learning, teacher unionism)
 - Through evidence problematise your broad area.
 - Identify your unit(s) of analysis
 - Identify the specific focus of your area of interest
 - Coin a working title

Few Parameters to be mindful of:

- a topic should be researchable
- Researchable problems are those which have a possibility of investigation, which can be through the analysis and collection of data.
- a research topic should be clear and well-focussed
- research issue is problematised
- a good research project must be narrowed down in order to be meaningful and manageable.

The best way to narrow your topic is to apply a few of the old familiar question words, like who, what, where, when, why, and how.

- Discipline in schools (what, where)
- Learning challenges in primary schools(what, where, why)
- Teacher stress (what, where, how, why)
- Teacher absenteeism in schools (what, where)

Examples of specific and researchable topics

- Educators' perceptions of the management of learner discipline in junior secondary schools in Libode district.
- Factors affecting the implementation of the New Curriculum Statement in high schools in Mthatha District

- The nature and extent of psycho-social challenges faced by children from child headed families in selected schools in Cofimvaba district.
- The role of Representative Council of Learners in school management in high schools in Gauteng Province.
- The nature and extent of child abuse by teachers in Harare secondary schools.

Background to the study

- the purpose is to demonstrate your understanding of your field by critically analyzing the pertinent work of other investigators leading up to your proposed work.
- placing study in context, conceptually and historically.
- general and broader description of the area of study
- the background should engage your readers with broad themes and topics.
- the background should illustrate your concepts, questions, and theory
- In placing your study in context by looking at what others have done, you need to identify the "gaps in our understanding" – concerns that suggest point to a problem to be addressed by the proposed study.

Statement of the problem

- Identify the specific problem your research study seeks to answer
- Show evidence that the problem exists and it is real, statistical evidence, what other studies say.
- Might be defined as the issue that exists in the literature, theory, or practice that leads to a need for the study
- Literature or research gap
- You should, ordinarily, state your main research questions or hypothesis at the end of this section

Purpose of the study

- The purpose of this study is to ...
- use words like; explore, compare, assess, establish etc.
- indicate the phenomenon you want to study
- indicate who will be involved in the study
- state where the research will be conducted

- there should be a direct link between your research title and purpose.

Research Questions

- Ideally, there should be a main RQ and sub-research questions
- Main research question is drawn from the title of the study e.g.
- Title: Perceptions of parent members of School Governing Bodies in their practice in the appointment of educators: A case study of four rural secondary schools in Cradock District
- Main Research Question: What are the perceptions of parent members of School Governing Bodies in their practice in the appointment of educators in four rural secondary schools in Cradock District

Sub- Research Questions

- These are questions that assist in the answering of the main research question hence they should feed into the main research question.
- These questions should not easily be answered 'yes' or 'no'. e.g.
- Do learners in junior secondary schools have reading problems? (Wrong)
- What the reading challenges experienced by learners in junior secondary schools? (Correct)
- Use 'what', 'how' and 'why' to formulate sub RQs
- Sub RQs should be few, so that focus is manageable about 3-4. Usually what, How, why

Hypotheses

- It is important to formulate hypotheses in quantitative studies
- A hypothesis provides a testable statement for the researcher
- Hypotheses are based on understanding variables
- Variable is, as the name suggests, something that varies
- On variables the researcher is simply asking;

a) Is X related to Y

b) What is the effect of X on Y

c) How are X1 and X2 related to Y

- Correlation – is there a relationship between X (independent variable) and Y (dependent variable) Is there any relationship between gender and reading performance?
- Comparative – is there a difference in Y (dependent variable) between people who have X characteristic (independent variable) and those who do not have X characteristic. Is there

any difference in the mastery of mathematical concepts between learners taught by individual instruction and those taught by group instruction?

Dependent variables (DI) and Independent variables (IV)

- the independent variable is the variable that is varied or manipulated by the researcher – it has direct effect on the dependent variable
- the dependent variable is the response that is measured.
- an independent variable is the presumed cause, whereas the dependent variable is the presumed effect
- the cause is called the independent variable; and the effect is called the dependent variable.

The following is a hypothesis for a study.

There is no statistically significant difference in graduation rates of at-risk students who participate in an intensive academic support programme as opposed to at-risk students who do not participate in the intensive academic support programme.

IV: Participation in intensive academic support programme

DV: Graduation rates

Examples of null hypotheses

In null hypotheses the researcher states that there is no relationship between variables

(Identify dependent and independent variables)

- There is no significant difference in the reading ability scores of learners in a school with English as medium of instruction and those in a school in which English is not the medium of instruction.
- There is no significant difference in the reading ability scores of boys and girls studying in the two types of schools.
- There is no significant correlation between parents' level of education and the learners' reading ability scores.
- There is no significant relationship between parents' occupation and learners' reading ability scores.

Research Objectives

- Research questions/Hypotheses are converted to research objectives.
- The number of your sub-research questions/hypotheses and the number of your research objectives should link.

Significance of the study

- Why is it important to do the study ?
- Identify the groups to whom the study shall be important and explain the ways in which the study will be important

Delimitation / Scope of the study

- You are defining the parameters/ boundaries of the study
- Conceptual boundary
- Geographical boundary
- The study shall focus on the financial management capabilities of SGBs. SGBs in rural senior secondary schools in Libode-Mega District shall be targetted. Practising members of SGBs shall participate in the study

Chapter Outline

- Describes the focus of each proposed chapter
- Each chapter's proposed contents are described in a few lines or a small paragraph
- The number of chapters is dependent on the student's understanding with the supervisor.
- A study can have 5, 6 or 7 chapters.

Literature Review

- LR is a critical synthesis of previous research
- A synthesis and analysis of the relevant published work linked to your work
- Literature review should :
- Compare and contrast different authors views on issue
- Group authors who draw similar conclusion
- Criticise aspects of methodology
- Note areas in which authors are in disagreement
- Highlight exemplary studies
- Highlight gaps in research
- Show how your study relates to previous studies
- Review depends on how you have organised your key points
- Remember to avoid plagiarising your sources

- Make sure you consistently reference the literature you are referring to
- We will probably not be able to do a complete review of all possible contributions to our field of research because of time constraints. It is crucial, therefore, to identify the key books and articles on the topic, in part by finding out who the most influential contributors are. It is a waste of time to 'go over old ground' and, in any event, we want to show we are up-to-date with the research area. Naturally, we are not interested in just doing a 'copy and paste' job on what we read but, rather, reading critically to find out the various points of view on offer and any possible disagreements or controversies that may exist

Research Methodology

- Research paradigm
- Research approach
- Research design
- Sampling procedure
- Data collection
- Data Analysis
- Validity and reliability
- Research ethics

Research paradigm

- Identify the research paradigm in which your proposed study is located
- Explain and justify the paradigm, showing why it is suitable for your proposed study
- Common research paradigms include positivism, interpretivism, post positivism

Research approaches

- Qualitative
- Quantitative
- Mixed Methods

Justify your choice of the approach:

- What is Qualitative or Quantitative or Mixed methods?
- Why is it important to use in your study?
- Why is it relevant to your study?

Research Designs

Research Design is a procedure that a researcher employs to collect, analyse, interpret and present data

Your design depends on the choice of approach. e.g.

Qualitative – Action research/Case Study/ethnography/Grounded Theory/Phenomenology/Historical research

Quantitative – Action research/ Correlational research/ Experimental research/ Quasi experimental/Surveys/ Ex post facto

Mixed Methods - Explanatory sequential design/ Exploratory sequential design/ Embedded design/ Convergent parallel design/ Concurrent triangulation design

Justify your choice of the design:

- What is (e.g.) a case study?
- Why is it important to use it in your study?
- Why is it relevant to your study

Sampling Procedures

Sampling involves selecting units of analysis (people, groups, artefacts, setting) in a manner that maximises the researcher's ability to answer research questions.

- Identify the main features of your sample
- Describe your sampling strategy

Justify your choice of sampling strategy:

- What is (e.g.) purposive sampling ?
- Why is it important to use it in your study?
- Why is it relevant to your study ?

Sampling Strategies

Qualitative – purposive sampling/snowball sa../Quota sampling

Quantitative - Simple Random sampling/ Systematic sampling/ Stratified Random sampling/ Cluster sampling/ Quota sampling/ Convenience sampling

Mixed Methods - Stratified purposive sampling / Random purposive sampling

Data Collection

Data collection refers to the general gathering of information

- Outline the general plan for collecting data. Include the instruments you propose to use, also depending on the choice of approach. E.g. Interviews, observations

Justify your choice of data collection strategy/ instrument

- What is (e.g.) interview?
- Why is it important to use in your study?
- Why is it relevant to your study?

Data collection strategies

Qualitative - Individual Interviews/ Focus group/ Observations/ Documents

Quantitative - Structured questionnaire/ Postal survey/ Telephone survey/ Email survey

Mixed Methods – interviews / Focus group/ observation/ Questionnaires/ survey

Data Analysis

- Specify and justify the procedures you will use in analysing your data
- Carefully explain how you will go about it

Validity & Reliability/ Credibility & Trustworthiness

Validity: determines whether the research truly measures that which it was intended to measure.

Reliability: the extent to which results are consistent over time, if the study can be reproduced under similar conditions.

- How are you going to guarantee/ensure validity and reliability in your study?
- Discuss in detail the strategies you will use to ensure validity and reliability and carefully explain how you will go about it.

Strategies

- Triangulation- Richardson (2000) prefers crystallisation
- Member checks
- Prolonged engagements in the field
- Pilot study and statistical checks to validate instruments

Research Ethics

- How will you protect the participants in your study?
- Whether there is harm to participants

- Whether there is invasion of privacy
- Whether deception is involved
- Whether there is lack of informed consent
- Detail procedures to follow in order to obtain informed consent and ensure anonymity and/or confidentiality
- Get ethics clearance from the University
- Get permission from the relevant authorities (department, schools)
- Informed consent- voluntarily, anonymity and/confidentiality

References

- Only references cited in the text are included in the reference list
- References should be done according to the APA style
- In-text referencing should be done correctly and consistently in line with the APA style